Rethinking Education in the Digital Age

Why modern learning must go beyond memorisation to develop critical thinking, creativity, practical skills and digital literacy.

By Allan Senteu

The 21st century demands a re-thinking of what learning should entail. Schools should do more than give students information and get them ready to take tests. Students should be taught how to think critically, solve problems, think creatively, communicate, and apply knowledge outside the classroom. The three themes outlined in the editorial are relevant in that they have the potential to alter the typical curriculum frameworks and cause schools to engage more directly with the way that students learn and apply knowledge.

First, learning must involve students in intense thinking, on the

higher levels of Bloom's taxonomy, especially analyzing, evaluating, and creating. I do not want to make students cons

umers of information. It is important to know facts, but it is not enough to show understanding of how to apply knowledge by simply memorizing facts. Student work should be challenged to analyze information, make connections, compare, contrast, assess evidence, problem solve, and generate new work. Students might, for instance, memorize facts about a historical event, or they might investigate the causes of the event, explore various points of view, and form

ulate an argument about the importance of the event. This method asks students to write down their reasoning instead of just giving an answer that is expected.

Also, I think that creative subjects should not be considered less important than traditionally academic subjects. Students can have multiple ways to solve problems and show understanding through music, art, and other creative activities. The aim is to create

students who will be able to think creatively and will be confident in solving problems that they have not experienced. A good curriculum should thus seek to elicit from the child something that has value rather than passively accept information be

ing fed to the child by the teacher.

Second, learning becomes more meaningful when students can grasp the relevance in their lives. When students know the purpose of a skill or concept, and how they could apply it in the

world beyond the classroom, they are more likely to be interested in learning it. I don't think that education

should be just a test-then-forget type thing. Knowledge needs to be applied in realistic contexts, and opportunities given for students to consider how they can put their knowledge to use.

Students should also be responsible for their own learning, which should grow in complexity. Sometimes, rather than being given a "recipe" to follow, they should be offered the cha

nce to choose how they will go about a problem, do a project, or show their understanding. This can facilitate the student to be a more independent and confident learner. I also feel that it is vital to reflect. Pupils should reflect regularly on their learning, how far they have come, any difficulties they faced, and how to improve. Assessment should therefore be more than just a grade. Feedback and

self-assessment on a regular basis can assist students in develop

ing a better picture of their progress and help them be more responsible for their learning.

But the student's audience is also important. When students are aware that no one except their teacher will see their work, they may be more concerned with finishing the assignment. Students have a better motivation to clearly communicate their ideas a

nd create something that is valued by themselves when they have chances to share their learning with peers, families, or the community.

Finally, the definition of

literacy has been altered in the digital era. The amount of information that students are exposed to today is vast through digital platforms, websites, videos, social media, and so on. Literacy involves more than the ability to read and write. Students should be able to locate, comprehend, appraise the reliability of,

plan, employ, and

share information responsibly with others.

Students should also use technology in a meaningful way, not just primarily by teachers. Students should be given opportunities to use the digital tools to explore questions, produce products, share ideas, work collaboratively with peers, and a*rticulate understanding. Meanwhile, they must understand that information*

on the Internet is not always accurate. Assessing and using information responsibly is part of

digital literacy.